



Maslenitsa

RUSSIA OFFICIALLY JOINED the Eastern Orthodox Church in 988 AD. Under communism, however, religion was condemned and many churches closed. Newly created holidays and pre-Christian celebrations like Maslenitsa replaced traditional Christian observance. Nevertheless, the Church, though suppressed, survived and is now enjoying renewed popularity.

An ancient tradition

Maslenitsa dates back to pre-Christian times. Its counterparts exist in the many festivals in the northern hemisphere that commemorate the rebirth of nature at the end of a long, dark winter. Different activities are assigned to each day of the week-long celebration including parties, sleigh rides, and even a day to visit grandparents.



LADY MASLENITSA

A straw dummy dressed as Lady Maslenitsa is made to accompany the festivities. She symbolizes the hope for a good spring and a successful harvest later in the year.

